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CENTRAL INTELLIGENCE AGENCY
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20505

DIRECTORATE OF SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY
OFFICE OF SCIENTIFIC INTELLIGENCE

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CONTROL NUMBER: PX-45-1126-OSI
FILE NUMBER: TS-1945-PX-001
SUBJECT: Recorded Conversation Between
Dr. J. Robert Oppenheimer and
Prof. Albert Einstein
Regarding "PHENOMENON-X"
DATE OF EVENT: 26 November 1945
LOCATION: Institute for Advanced Study
Princeton, New Jersey
DATE COMPILED: 18 March 1954 (OSI Report)
LAST UPDATED: 18 March 1964 (Memorandum)
DECLASSIFIED: 6 August 1995
AUTHORITY: Executive Order 12958

WARNING NOTICE — INTELLIGENCE SOURCES AND METHODS INVOLVED

This document contains information affecting the national defense of the United States within the meaning of Title 18, United States Code, Sections 793 and 794. The transmission or revelation of its contents in any manner to an unauthorized person is prohibited by law.

ARCHIVAL NOTE: This electronic file is a composite archive compiled from wartime CIC counterintelligence records (1945), postwar OSI analytical memoranda (1954), and subsequent Directorate review documents (1964). The original 1945 recording was obtained by the U.S. Army Counter Intelligence Corps. Voice comparison performed by Army Signal Intelligence confirms the recorded speakers. The transcript was reconstructed from the original steel-wire recording. This CREST posting supersedes the 1995 paper declassification release and includes previously redacted administrative annotations restored under automatic declassification review (2006).

CIA RECORDS SEARCH TOOL (CREST)
CREST Record No.: C05891673
Date Posted: 12 March 2006

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I. BACKGROUND

The following memorandum reproduces portions of an audio recording obtained during a counterintelligence surveillance operation conducted at the Institute for Advanced Study, Princeton, New Jersey, on 26 November 1945.

At the time of collection, the surveillance operation was authorized solely for the purpose of monitoring postwar foreign scientific contacts involving Professor Albert Einstein. The recording equipment, an experimental wire recorder concealed within the base of a desk lamp, captured approximately three hours of private discussion between Professor Einstein and Dr. J. Robert Oppenheimer.

The overwhelming majority of the conversation concerned postwar scientific policy, international control of atomic weapons, the future organization of nuclear research, and political relations with the Soviet Union.

Approximately one hour and forty-two minutes into the discussion, both participants departed from conventional scientific subjects and began discussing an unidentified phenomenon referred to repeatedly as "PHENOMENON-X."

Because no supporting evidence existed in 1945, this section of the conversation was originally classified as speculative philosophical discussion and archived without further investigation. Following multiple intelligence reports collected between 1952 and 1954 concerning unexplained biological anomalies, the termination of Project PERSEPHONE, and several previously unrelated wartime intelligence files captured from German research organizations, Agency analysts re-examined the original recording.

The material reproduced below represents the first known occasion on which two leading theoretical physicists independently associated high-energy nuclear phenomena with a separate category of unidentified biological entities already appearing in classified military reporting.

For analytical purposes only, the designation "PHENOMENON-X" was subsequently adopted throughout the Intelligence Community as the umbrella reference for these reports.

The transcript begins at Timestamp 01:42:13 of the original recording.

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II. TRANSCRIPT OF RECORDED CONVERSATION

Transcript reconstructed from original steel-wire recording. Background noise, pauses, and unintelligible segments annotated where applicable.

[Background noise: fireplace burning. Chairs moving.]

EINSTEIN:

You did not come here to discuss politics.

OPPENHEIMER:

No.

EINSTEIN:

Nor victory.

OPPENHEIMER:

No.

[Pause: approximately 8 seconds.]

OPPENHEIMER:

At Trinity... there was something else. Not the explosion. Not the fireball. Something after it.

EINSTEIN:

You mean the photographs?

OPPENHEIMER:

No. The instruments. The spectroscopy team believed it was an equipment malfunction. I no longer think so. At approximately one point two seconds after detonation -- there appeared an absorption feature. One spectral line. It existed for less than one-third of a second. No known element matches it. No isotope. No plasma process. Nothing.

EINSTEIN:

And what conclusion did your people reach?

OPPENHEIMER:

Officially? Instrument error. Unofficially... we opened captured German archives. The SS research division. Ahnenerbe. They had been looking for the same thing. They called it... "Gottesrest." Our translators rendered it as "That Which Was Left Behind." Their physicists believed that when enough energy is released within an extremely short interval -- conditions briefly resemble those that existed at Creation. For an instant... the universe remembers.

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EINSTEIN:

That sounds less like physics... and more like theology.

OPPENHEIMER:

I thought so too. Until I read the measurements. Their spectral diagrams. Their laboratory notebooks. They had observed the same absorption line. Years before us. Not during an explosion. During biological experiments.

[Silence.]

EINSTEIN:

Continue.

OPPENHEIMER:

Their reports described women. Not many. Exceptionally rare. Their blood exhibited the identical spectral discontinuity. One page contains a sentence underlined three times. "The fragment is not contained within the body. The body is contained around the fragment."

[Recorder noise.]

EINSTEIN:

Interesting wording.

OPPENHEIMER:

They believed the organism was merely... a vessel. The phenomenon itself was something older. Much older. Perhaps older than life. Perhaps older than physics.

EINSTEIN:

Or perhaps... physics has always been incomplete.

[Pause: approximately 11 seconds. Chair creaks. Footsteps.]

EINSTEIN:

Do you remember what I have said for nearly twenty years?

OPPENHEIMER:

That God does not play dice.

EINSTEIN:

People quote the sentence. Almost no one understands it. When I say that God does not play dice -- I do not mean the universe lacks uncertainty. I mean... creation possesses intention. Every equation ultimately asks the same question. Why does reality choose this outcome instead of another? Your physicists search for particles. I searched for necessity.

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OPPENHEIMER:

And now?

EINSTEIN:

Now I believe we have both been asking the wrong question. The question is not -- "What is missing from physics?" The question is -- "What remains after creation ended?"

[Recorder hiss.]

OPPENHEIMER:

The German documents suggest that whatever remained... can attach itself to certain people.

EINSTEIN:

Perhaps. Or perhaps attachment is merely our primitive vocabulary. Imagine a sculptor. He carves a statue. When he finishes, marble dust remains on the floor. No one studies the dust. Everyone admires the statue. But suppose... the dust retained memory of the sculpture it once belonged to. Suppose every grain still attempted to become whole. Then every fragment would forever seek something capable of carrying it. Not because it is alive. Not because it possesses intention. Simply because incompleteness has direction.

OPPENHEIMER:

You are describing a conservation law.

EINSTEIN:

Exactly. Not conservation of mass. Not conservation of energy. Conservation of completion. Nothing unfinished simply disappears. It waits. Sometimes for centuries. Perhaps longer.

[Long pause.]

OPPENHEIMER:

Then Trinity...

EINSTEIN:

...may have produced conditions under which that residue became visible. Only briefly. Like lightning illuminating a mountain range. The mountain was always there. You merely saw it.

OPPENHEIMER:

The absorption line. The biological specimens. The German observations. They are all manifestations of the same phenomenon?

EINSTEIN:

I do not know. I am old enough to admit the difference between belief and evidence. But I know this. When independent observations, made decades apart, by people pursuing entirely different goals, all point toward the same unknown... a physicist should become cautious, not dismissive.

[Background noise: glass placed on wooden table.]

EINSTEIN:

The greatest mistake science can make is not believing impossible things. It is believing that everything impossible must therefore be imaginary.

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[Pause: approximately 7 seconds.]

OPPENHEIMER:

There is something I have not included in any official report. Not to General Groves. Not to the Interim Committee. Not even to the President.

EINSTEIN:

Because you fear they would not believe you?

OPPENHEIMER:

No. Because I am afraid they would.

[Recorder noise.]

OPPENHEIMER:

In September of last year... I was escorted into a restricted laboratory at Los Alamos. The building was absent from every engineering blueprint. Its personnel files were compartmentalized outside the Manhattan District. The Army called it a biological containment facility. It was neither biological nor medical. There was a woman there. Designation only. No name. No service record. No birth certificate. No fingerprints in any federal archive. Only a codename. "PERSEPHONE."

[Pause.]

EINSTEIN:

You met her.

OPPENHEIMER:

Only once. They instructed me not to approach the glass. Not to speak first. Not to remain longer than sixty seconds. I violated the second instruction.

[Silence.]

EINSTEIN:

What happened?

OPPENHEIMER:

Nothing. That was the disturbing part. She did not attempt escape. She did not threaten anyone. She simply looked at me. I have spent years watching men calculate critical mass. Watching explosions. Watching reactors come alive. I know what concentrated energy feels like. She felt... older. Not stronger. Older. As though every object inside that room -- including myself -- had arrived long after she had.

[Recorder hiss.]

OPPENHEIMER:

I asked her -- "Who are you?" She smiled. Not pleasantly. Not cruelly. Simply... with recognition. Then she asked me a question.

EINSTEIN:

What question?

[Pause: approximately 5 seconds.]

OPPENHEIMER:

She said -- "Are you certain the fire you created is the first fire of its kind?"

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[Silence: 14 seconds.]

OPPENHEIMER:

No scientist has ever asked me a question that frightened me. She did. Because I realized... I had already assumed the answer.

EINSTEIN:

And assumptions are where civilizations make their greatest mistakes.

OPPENHEIMER:

I left immediately. I never requested another visit. Three weeks later, the spectroscopy division reported the Trinity anomaly. I have never been able to separate the two events in my own mind.

[Background noise: glass being refilled.]

EINSTEIN:

Perhaps you should not. Some discoveries are connected long before we possess the mathematics to connect them.

[Pause: approximately 12 seconds.]

EINSTEIN:

Do you know... what frightened me most when I completed the field equations?

OPPENHEIMER:

The mathematics?

EINSTEIN:

No. The elegance. Reality should not be that elegant. Every equation balanced. Every tensor resolved. Every term possessed its necessity. For several weeks... I believed I had described the entire architecture of the universe. Then I began asking a simpler question. If the universe is complete... why does history continue producing things that refuse to fit inside it?

[Recorder hiss.]

EINSTEIN:

Every generation believes it has discovered an exception. Miracles. Prophets. Saints. Witches. Visions. Hallucinations. Each age invents new vocabulary. Yet the reports never truly change. The witnesses change. The language changes. The phenomenon remains. That should concern every physicist.

OPPENHEIMER:

You think these accounts describe the same reality?

EINSTEIN:

I think they describe the same absence. Imagine reading a book with one page missing. Every reader notices the gap. None of them describe it the same way. A priest calls it divine mystery. A philosopher calls it metaphysics. A physician calls it hysteria. A soldier calls it battlefield shock. A physicist calls it experimental error. Different names. The same missing page.

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[Silence.]

OPPENHEIMER:

Then what are those women?

EINSTEIN:

I cannot answer that. Not honestly. But I suspect they are not an anomaly within nature. They are evidence that nature is larger than the version we have succeeded in describing.

[Pause.]

EINSTEIN:

Physicists possess an unfortunate habit. Whenever something cannot be measured -- we pretend it does not exist. The universe has never agreed to that arrangement.

OPPENHEIMER:

Then Trinity... did not create the phenomenon.

EINSTEIN:

No. At most... you illuminated it. For less than half a second. Long enough for your instruments to notice. Long enough for you to begin asking the correct questions. Unfortunately... history rarely rewards those who ask the correct questions first.

[Subject Einstein laughs quietly. Duration approximately two seconds.]

EINSTEIN:

It usually buries them under classified files.

[Background noise: fireplace. Wind audible outside.]

OPPENHEIMER:

If you are correct... then every government that discovers evidence of this phenomenon will attempt the same thing. Contain it. Measure it. Weaponize it.

EINSTEIN:

Of course. Governments do not fear what they understand. They fear what refuses to obey them.

OPPENHEIMER:

The Army believes the specimen at Los Alamos may possess military value. Some think its biological properties can be reproduced. Others believe the phenomenon itself can be transferred.

EINSTEIN:

Can lightning be transferred? Can gravity? Can time? Human beings have a talent for mistaking observation for ownership. You discovered uranium. You did not invent it. You measured gravity. You did not create it. If this phenomenon is fundamental -- it belongs to the universe, not to governments.

[Pause: approximately 6 seconds.]

OPPENHEIMER:

Suppose they refuse to accept that. Suppose they continue.

EINSTEIN:

Then they will discover the oldest law in science. Every experiment eventually begins to observe its observer.

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[Recorder interference: approximately 1.3 seconds.]

OPPENHEIMER:

The German files contained one sentence I could never understand.

EINSTEIN:

Which one?

OPPENHEIMER:

"The phenomenon never hides. Only the observer fails to arrive." I dismissed it as mysticism. Now... I am uncertain.

EINSTEIN:

Perhaps because it was written by someone who had already failed. History often leaves its best warnings inside the notebooks of defeated men. Unfortunately, victors seldom read them carefully.

[Silence.]

EINSTEIN:

Robert... promise me something.

OPPENHEIMER:

If I can.

EINSTEIN:

If one day your government concludes that these women are merely another strategic resource... walk away. Do not help them. Physics has already given mankind one Prometheus. It does not require another.

[Pause.]

OPPENHEIMER:

You believe we crossed a line at Trinity.

EINSTEIN:

No. I believe you crossed a doorway. A line can be stepped back across. A doorway cannot be unopened. What worries me is not that humanity has learned how to split the atom. What worries me is that something else... may now know that humanity has learned.

[End of audible conversation for approximately 27 seconds. Subjects continue speaking at volume below transcription threshold.]

[Audio level restored. Background noise: water being poured into two glasses.]

EINSTEIN:

May I ask you something, Robert?

OPPENHEIMER:

Of course.

EINSTEIN:

When you watched the Trinity explosion -- what did you feel first? Pride? Fear? Relief?

OPPENHEIMER:

None of them. Recognition.

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[Pause.]

OPPENHEIMER:

That is what troubles me. The fireball rose... and for a single instant I had the impossible certainty that I had seen it before. Not in memory. Not in dreams. Somewhere... deeper than either. As if the human mind already possessed a place prepared for it. As though history had been waiting for that image.

EINSTEIN:

An archetype.

OPPENHEIMER:

If you wish. But archetypes do not produce spectral anomalies. They do not alter instrument readings. They do not appear simultaneously to every observer using independent equipment.

[Subjects speaking more quietly.]

EINSTEIN:

There is an old misconception among scientists. We assume that discovery occurs at the moment an experiment succeeds. It does not. Discovery begins much earlier -- the moment reality behaves unexpectedly. Everything afterward is merely bookkeeping.

OPPENHEIMER:

Then perhaps we have already begun a field of science without realizing it.

EINSTEIN:

No. You have begun a responsibility. Science can describe phenomena. Responsibility determines what mankind chooses to do with them. Those are not the same profession.

[Long pause.]

OPPENHEIMER:

The military will ask me whether this phenomenon can be controlled. What should I tell them?

EINSTEIN:

Tell them the truth.

OPPENHEIMER:

Which is?

EINSTEIN:

That after three hundred years of modern science, we still cannot control gravity. We cannot control radioactivity. We cannot control time. We merely learn how not to stand in their way. Why should this be different?

[Silence.]

OPPENHEIMER:

And if they insist?

EINSTEIN:

Then they will spend billions of dollars attempting to command something they first should have understood. Governments have done so many times before. History calls those efforts empires. Physics calls them failed experiments.

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[Recorder hiss.]

OPPENHEIMER:

There is one possibility I have never shared with anyone.

EINSTEIN:

Go on.

OPPENHEIMER:

Suppose these women are not the phenomenon. Suppose they are simply the only people who survived contact with it.

[Silence: 18 seconds.]

EINSTEIN:

... That... is the first question you have asked tonight that genuinely frightens me.

III. CONTINUING DISCUSSION

[Recorder resumes. Estimated elapsed time: approximately 2 minutes. Fireplace. Wind against window.]

OPPENHEIMER:

If what we have discussed is even partially correct... then this conversation cannot remain between ourselves.

EINSTEIN:

You are thinking like an advisor. Not like a physicist.

OPPENHEIMER:

I am both.

EINSTEIN:

That is precisely the problem.

[Pause.]

OPPENHEIMER:

The President must be informed. The Army must be informed. Someone has to know.

EINSTEIN:

Someone always knows. The question is -- what happens after they know?

[Recorder hiss.]

EINSTEIN:

Governments are incapable of leaving mysteries alone. Every unknown eventually receives a budget. Every budget demands results. Every result demands application. Sooner or later, someone will ask whether it can be used. Not because they are evil. Because institutions have only one instinct. Expansion.

OPPENHEIMER:

You believe they will attempt to weaponize it.

EINSTEIN:

No. I believe they will fail to distinguish between understanding and possession. Those are different things. History repeatedly confuses them.

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[Silence.]

OPPENHEIMER:

Suppose the phenomenon cannot be possessed.

EINSTEIN:

Then mankind will spend decades trying. And when nothing works, they will conclude the phenomenon does not exist. That is the safer lie.

OPPENHEIMER:

Safer for whom?

EINSTEIN:

For governments. Not necessarily for civilization.

[Pause: approximately 9 seconds.]

OPPENHEIMER:

The German files contained another note. No author. No signature. Only one sentence. "The observer must never become the experiment." At the time I thought it referred to radiation exposure. Now... I am no longer certain.

EINSTEIN:

Neither am I.

[Subjects speaking quietly.]

EINSTEIN:

There are discoveries that enlarge civilization. Electricity. Vaccination. Relativity. There are discoveries that merely enlarge its power. Those are not the same category. And then -- there exists a third category. Discoveries that alter how mankind understands itself. Those should never belong to soldiers. Nor politicians. Perhaps... not even physicists.

[Long silence.]

OPPENHEIMER:

Then who?

EINSTEIN:

History. Leave certain answers to history. It is slower than governments. But considerably wiser.

[Recorder interference: approximately 0.8 seconds.]

EINSTEIN:

If one day another generation possesses evidence greater than ours -- let them judge. Our responsibility is much smaller. Preserve the evidence. Do not embellish it. Do not explain what you cannot prove. And above all -- do not mistake ignorance for certainty.

[Pause.]

OPPENHEIMER:

Then the record should remain sealed.

EINSTEIN:

For as long as necessary. Not to protect the truth. To protect people from believing they already possess it.

[Conversation continues beyond this point. Remaining discussion concerns international nuclear governance and is filed separately under AEC-1945-NUCLEAR-17.]

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IV. ANALYST'S COMMENTS

Document Reference: PX-45-1126-TRANSCRIPT

Prepared: 17 December 1945 (CIC)
Reviewed: 18 March 1954 (OSI, CIA)

1. AUTHENTICITY. The attached transcript has been reconstructed from an original steel-wire recording obtained through Counter Intelligence Corps operational surveillance. Voice comparison performed by Army Signal Intelligence personnel confirms, with high confidence, that the recorded speakers are Professor Albert Einstein and Dr. J. Robert Oppenheimer. No evidence of editing, interruption, or mechanical alteration has been identified within the surviving recording. The transcript should therefore be regarded as an authentic record of a private discussion, although no claims made by either participant have, at present, been independently verified.
2. SCIENTIFIC ASSESSMENT. Several technical references contained within the discussion correspond to classified data generated during the Manhattan Engineer District. These include: spectroscopic measurements recorded during the Trinity Test; reports concerning unidentified absorption features; internal discussions regarding unexplained instrument anomalies; and references to captured German scientific material recovered under ALSOS operations. While no currently accepted physical theory supports the conclusions suggested by the participants, none of the referenced technical measurements have yet been satisfactorily explained by existing analysis. The possibility that multiple independent observations share a common unidentified cause cannot presently be excluded.
3. INTELLIGENCE ASSESSMENT. Professor Einstein repeatedly discourages the weaponization of the unidentified phenomenon discussed herein. Dr. Oppenheimer expresses concern that continued military investigation may produce strategic consequences extending beyond currently understood nuclear research. Neither participant proposes immediate operational action. The discussion remains philosophical in tone, though repeatedly references classified scientific material unavailable to the public. For this reason, dissemination should remain strictly compartmented.
4. RECOMMENDATION. It is recommended that all future reports containing references to the unidentified spectroscopic anomaly described herein be assigned to an independent compartment under the provisional designation: PHENOMENON-X. No reference to this compartment shall appear within ordinary Manhattan Engineer District filing systems. Cross-indexing with foreign intelligence, atomic weapons research, biological warfare, or medical experimentation should require Director-level authorization. Pending additional physical evidence, the official position of the United States Government shall remain that no verified phenomenon corresponding to the contents of this transcript has been observed.

Prepared by:

[REDACTED]

Scientific Intelligence Analyst
Office of Scientific Intelligence
Central Intelligence Agency

Reviewed and Approved:

[REDACTED]

Chief, Office of Scientific Intelligence

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ADDENDUM A

TERMINATION OF PROJECT PERSEPHONE

FILE REFERENCE: PX-45-1126
DATE: 18 May 1954
ORIGINATING: Office of Scientific Intelligence, CIA

BACKGROUND

On 14 May 1954, Subject PERSEPHONE expired at the Army biological research installation, Fort Detrick, Maryland. Official medical determination lists the cause of death as acute cardiac failure. No conventional pathological condition capable of explaining the terminal event has been identified. Subject age remains undetermined. No verified birth record has ever been located. No authenticated family members have been identified. Fingerprint comparison against federal, state and military archives produced negative results. Subject therefore remains officially classified as an unidentified civilian under federal custody.

POST-MORTEM OBSERVATIONS

Autopsy was conducted under joint supervision of Army Medical Corps personnel and Office of Scientific Intelligence observers. The examination produced several findings considered inconsistent with accepted human physiology. These observations remain unverified and should not be interpreted as established scientific fact. Observed anomalies include: (a) Abnormal persistence of cellular integrity significantly exceeding expected rates following clinical death. (b) Blood samples exhibiting spectroscopic absorption characteristics similar to those documented during Trinity Test Instrument Report S-16. (c) Tissue degeneration proceeding normally despite continued preservation of several unidentified microscopic structures. (d) Metallic ion concentration exceeding accepted physiological reference values, while producing no evidence of heavy-metal toxicity. Repeated laboratory analysis failed to identify contamination or measurement error. Independent laboratories reproduced the same measurements. No satisfactory explanation has been obtained.

PROJECT STATUS

Project PERSEPHONE is hereby terminated. No additional human experimentation is authorized. Remaining biological specimens shall be transferred under armed escort to the Special Biological Repository, Fort Detrick. Access authorization is restricted to: Director of Central Intelligence; Director, Office of Scientific Intelligence; Chairman, Atomic Energy Commission; Secretary of Defense (or specifically designated representative). No specimen shall be transferred to civilian universities, private contractors, or foreign governments without written Presidential authorization.

ASSESSMENT

The death of Subject PERSEPHONE has not resolved any of the principal scientific questions raised by Project PHENOMENON-X. Instead, it has eliminated the only known living source from which

controlled observation was possible. Accordingly, further investigation shall shift emphasis from biological containment to passive intelligence collection. Priority shall be given to historical records, foreign archival material, unexplained medical case reports, optical and spectroscopic anomalies, and any future observation displaying measurable correspondence with Trinity Instrument Report S-16.

The Office of Scientific Intelligence does not presently recommend renewed containment efforts. Available evidence suggests that the phenomenon, if genuine, cannot be adequately studied through conventional detention procedures. Future operations should emphasize observation rather than acquisition.

Approved,

[REDACTED]

Chief, Office of Scientific Intelligence
Central Intelligence Agency
18 May 1954

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MEMORANDUM FOR THE DIRECTOR OF CENTRAL INTELLIGENCE

DOCUMENT NO.: PX-64-0318-MEMO
DATE: 18 March 1964
FROM: Deputy Director for Intelligence
SUBJECT: Recommendation for Reopening Investigation
into PHENOMENON-X
REFERENCES: PX-45-1126-TRANSCRIPT; ADDENDUM A (1954);
AEC Scientific Memorandum S-16;
Fort Detrick Biological Report BD-54-117

This memorandum recommends the formal reactivation of investigative activities associated with PHENOMENON-X. The recommendation is based upon scientific developments occurring during the period 1958-1964 which were unavailable at the time previous evaluations were completed. Following termination of Project PERSEPHONE in 1954, active collection concerning PHENOMENON-X was substantially reduced. The Office of Scientific Intelligence maintained archival review responsibilities, but no dedicated operational program remained in existence. This position was considered acceptable until recent developments in molecular biology produced observations that could not be reconciled with prior assumptions.

Between 1961 and 1963, multiple biological laboratories operating under separate government contracts reported unidentified structural irregularities within chromosomal preparations obtained from archived tissue specimens originally collected under Project PERSEPHONE. The laboratories reached these observations independently. None were informed of the origin of the samples. Although terminology differs between laboratories, each report describes an additional microscopic structure located adjacent to chromosomal material. The structure does not stain consistently under conventional preparation techniques. Its optical characteristics vary according to illumination wavelength. Repeated examination has failed to determine whether the structure represents biological material, preparation artifact, or an unidentified physical process. Current scientific methodology provides no satisfactory explanation.

Review of the Trinity spectroscopic records, captured German research documents, and Project PERSEPHONE laboratory notebooks identified several previously overlooked correspondences. These similarities remain circumstantial. No causal relationship has been established. Nevertheless, their cumulative statistical occurrence is now considered sufficiently unusual to justify renewed investigation. Accordingly, the previous assessment that all reported anomalies represented unrelated events is no longer considered fully adequate.

Interviews conducted with individuals maintaining professional contact with Dr. J. Robert Oppenheimer between 1955 and 1963 indicate a noticeable change in research interests following his November 1945 meeting with Professor Einstein. Witnesses consistently describe an increased interest in subjects unrelated to theoretical physics, including: medieval inquisitorial archives, comparative religious history, historical epidemic records, ancient cosmological traditions, and reports of unexplained biological events. No evidence has been obtained indicating that Dr. Oppenheimer publicly disclosed classified information. His continuing interest is therefore assessed as personal rather than operational.

Current evidence remains insufficient to establish the existence of PHENOMENON-X as an objective physical phenomenon. However, current evidence is equally insufficient to dismiss the accumulated observations as coincidence. The Office of Scientific Intelligence therefore recommends restoration of restricted investigative activities under compartmented access procedures. No public disclosure is recommended. Distribution shall remain limited to personnel possessing PHENOMENON-X authorization.

RECOMMENDATIONS

1. PHENOMENON-X be restored as an active compartment.
2. All future anomalous biological reports be cross-indexed against existing files.
3. Foreign intelligence stations be instructed to preserve -- not pursue -- any information displaying correspondence with previous observations.
4. Existing archival material remain exempt from automatic declassification schedules.

Prepared by:

[REDACTED]

Senior Scientific Analyst
Office of Scientific Intelligence

Approved:

[REDACTED]

Deputy Director for Intelligence
Central Intelligence Agency
18 March 1964

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DECLASSIFICATION RECORD

DATE OF DECLASSIFICATION: 6 August 1995

AUTHORITY:
CIA CASE NUMBER:

Executive Order 12958
RDP96-00788R001700210016-5

This document was reviewed by the CIA Declassification Review Board on 6 August 1995, in accordance with the provisions of Executive Order 12958, and approved for release. Redactions were applied to the names of CIA and Army intelligence personnel below the threshold of historical significance, consistent with statutory exemptions protecting intelligence sources and methods under the Freedom of Information Act, 5 U.S.C. Section 552, as amended.

The original steel-wire recording remains classified and is held in the CIA Office of Scientific Intelligence audio archive under restricted access. Transcripts PX-45-1126-TRANSCRIPT-003 through PX-45-1126-TRANSCRIPT-008 remain classified in their entirety under FOIA exemption (b)(1) (properly classified pursuant to Executive Order). No date has been established for their automatic declassification.

The electronic version of this document was uploaded to the CIA Records Search Tool (CREST) on 12 March 2006 as part of the Agency's ongoing effort to provide public access to historically significant intelligence records. This electronic posting supersedes the 1995 paper release and includes minor administrative annotations restored under subsequent automatic declassification review.

END OF DOCUMENT

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